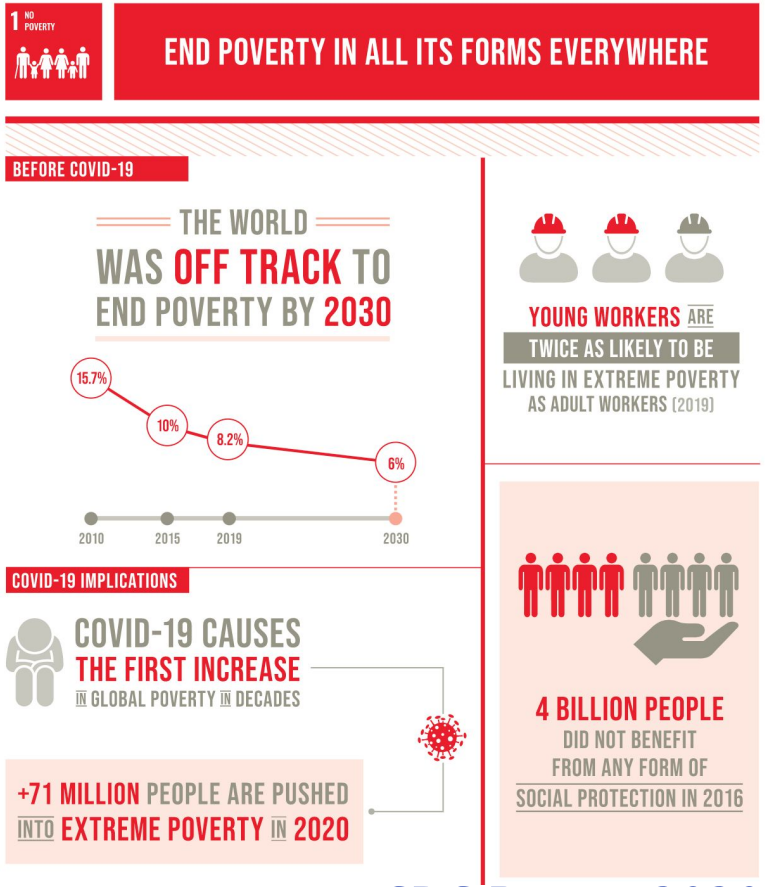
Creating Infographics with Canva

Digital Integration Teaching Initiative (DITI)
Taught by Sara Morrell & Yuntong Ji
Prof. Kevin Drakulich
CRIM 4949 | Fall 2026

Workshop Agenda

- Learn about dynamic and static modes of conveying information.
- Discuss best practices for visualizing data.
- Explore how to make visualizations using Canva, a free online tool.
- Consider accessibility in designing presentations and infographics.

Slides and handout available at:
bit.ly/fa26-drakulich-crim4949-infographics



SDG Report 2020

Infographics

Feel free to ask questions at any point during the presentation!

Infographics Basics 1/2

- Infographics present complex information quickly and clearly.
- Infographics tell a story with **structure** and **sequence**, and are most often images combined with numbers, charts, graphs, and summary text.
- Infographics **concisely** convey information and data to different audiences **across platforms and media** (i.e., digital or print).

Infographics Basics 2/2

- Infographics have **narrow** focus or subject matter, **short** and accessible titles, and provide **citations** for all of the information included.
- Infographics consider **accessibility**: Make sure text is not cut off or covered by images, add descriptive alt-text to your infographic image file.

For more information on **accessibility**, please see: **DITI accessibility handout**

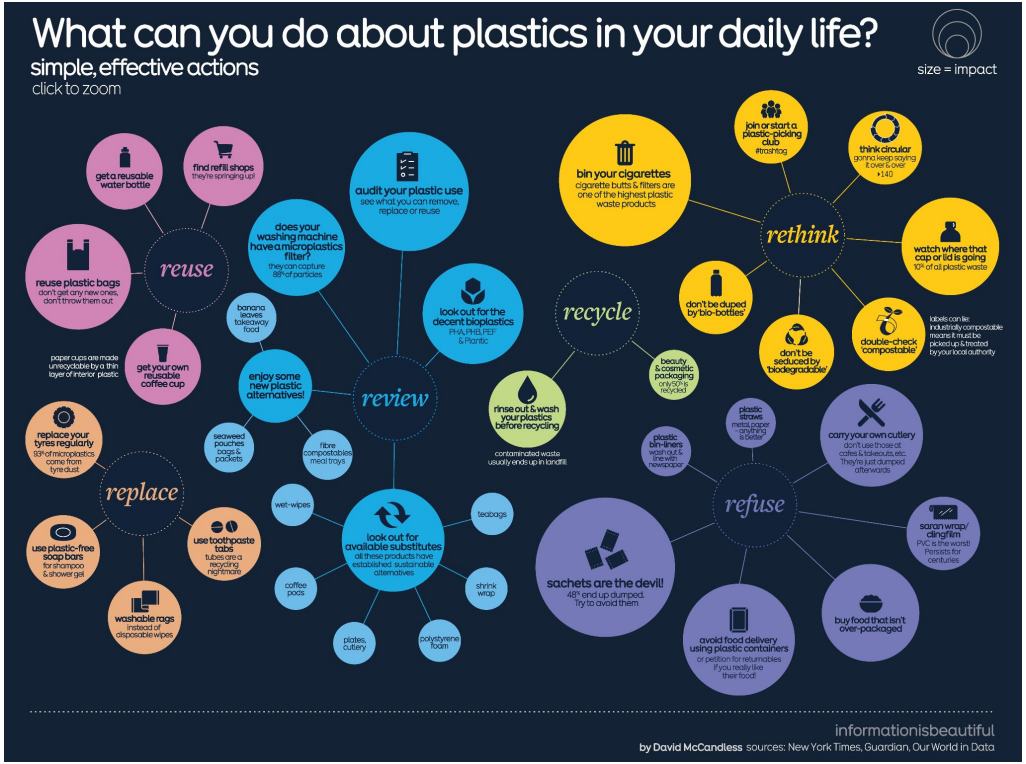
Why Use Infographics?

Infographics as a genre of communication have unique affordances and limitations.

Their concise nature and combined visual-verbal modes are great for quickly and efficiently communicating key information. However, as a result, infographics also provide you with very limited space, requiring you to think critically beforehand about what data you want to prioritize, what information is the most important to convey, etc.

Infographics Example 1

- What message/information is this infographic conveying? To whom?
- Why do you think the creator chose to communicate via infographic?



Source: *"What can you do about plastics in your daily life?", David McCandless, Information is Beautiful*

Infographics Example 2

- Who is the audience for this infographic?
- How do you think that the visual style enhances (or potentially detracts from) the information?
- What similarities and/or differences do you see between this infographic and the previous?



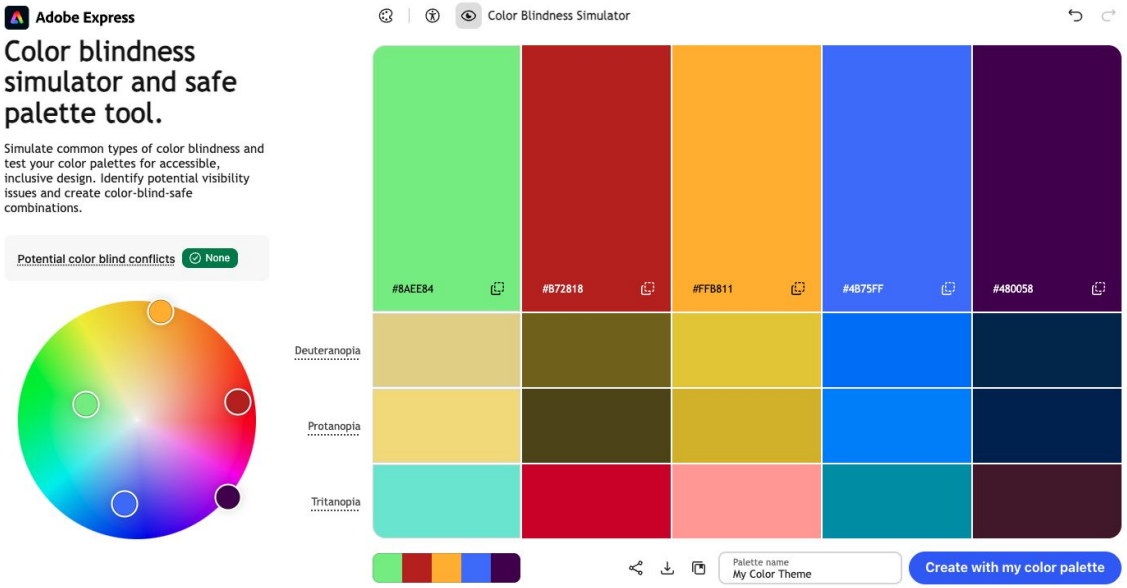
Source: *"BPL 2025 Snapshot," The Massachusetts Board of Library Commissioners (MBLC)*

Keep it Visible: Colors

- Make color choices that are accessible to everyone (and appropriate for the presentation).
- Ideal color schemes are **high contrast** (use a contrast checker).
- Think about limiting your palette (3 colors can be effective).
- NU Colors provides the Northeastern University palette.
- Use Colorblind Safe Color Schemes

Colorblind Safe Color Schemes

- Adobe offers an online [color blindness palette tool]
- You can use this tool to ensure that your color palette is accessible



Source: [Color blindness simulator and safe palette tool] by Adobe

Getting Started with Canva

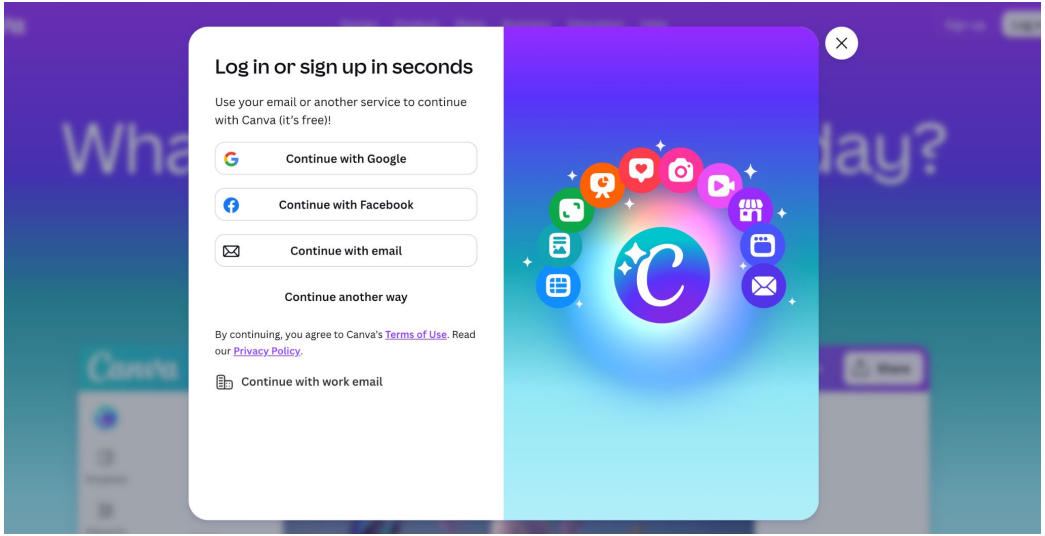
Feel free to ask questions at any point during the presentation!

Data Privacy

- It's important to pay attention to data privacy when using digital resources
- At its simplest, **data privacy** is a person's ability to control what of their personal information is shared and with whom.
- To help you make informed decisions about interacting with digital tools in ways that honor your boundaries with your data and/or personal information, The DITI has prepared a handout on **Data Privacy**

Sign up/Login

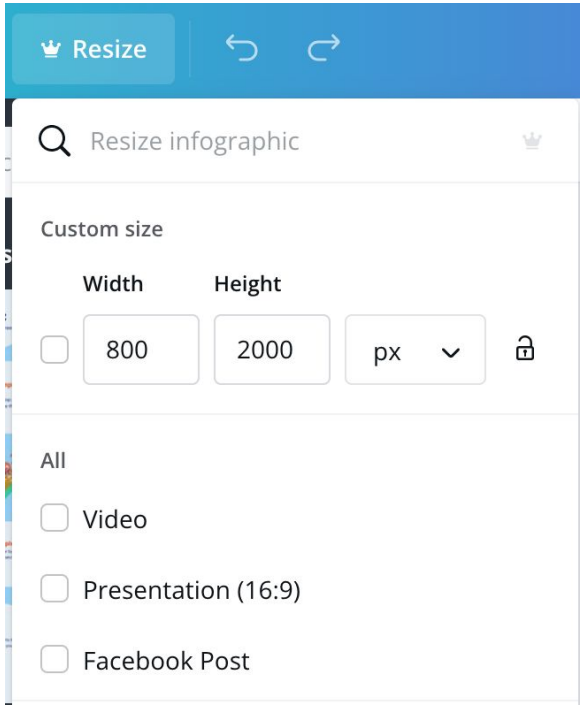
- Canva is a free online infographic maker.
- Use your Google/Facebook/or Email to sign up or log in.
- Click “Create”



Feel free to ask questions at any point during the presentation!

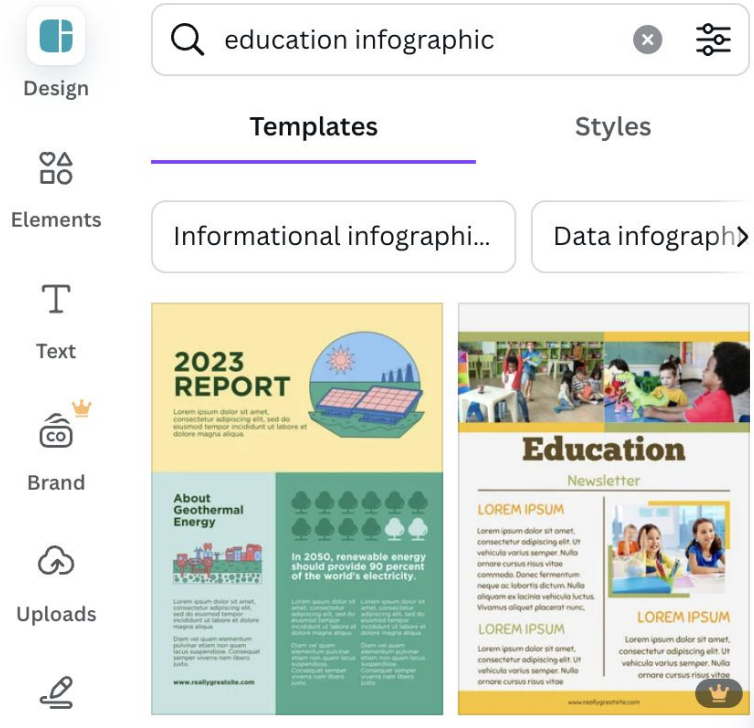
Starting Up...

- First, pick your canvas dimensions. Canva features a curated 'infographic' size, but you can customize the width and length when opening a new graphic. You can also add more 'pages.'
  - Unfortunately, resizing and adding pages in an already existing graphic is only available in paid subscriptions.
- Infographics work best when presenting information through one direction, so it might help to size your canvas as being long either vertically or horizontally.



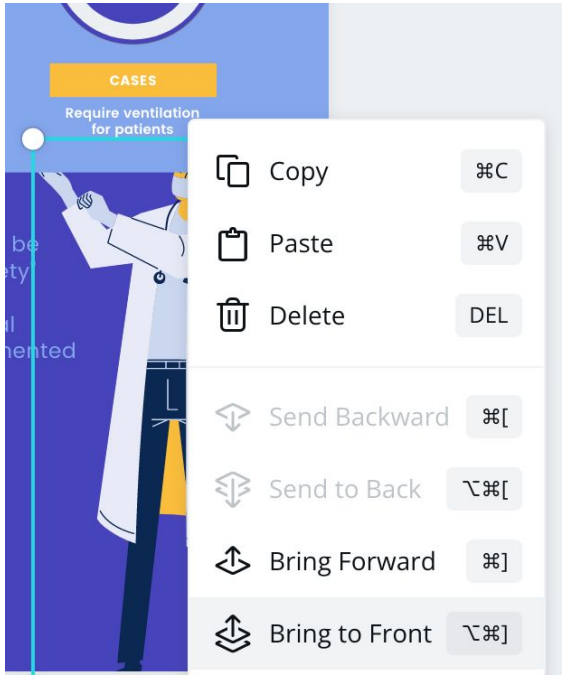
Pick a Style

- Infographics work best when presented in a uniform style.
- Try to get your information and your design to work together!
- If you need some help or inspiration, Canva offers several infographic templates you can start from.

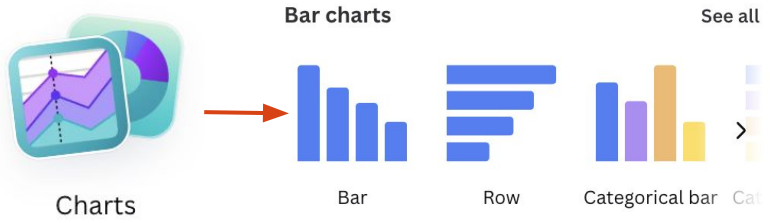


Layers

- Canva works by combining several graphic layers.
- Layers can be anything that shows up on the canvas—elements, charts, text, etc.—and can be customized in many ways. You can drag them around, change their colors, resize them, and more!
- Remember that you can always send a layer ‘forward’ or ‘back’ relative to other layers with a right click on PC, control click on Macs (or use the key commands shown at right)



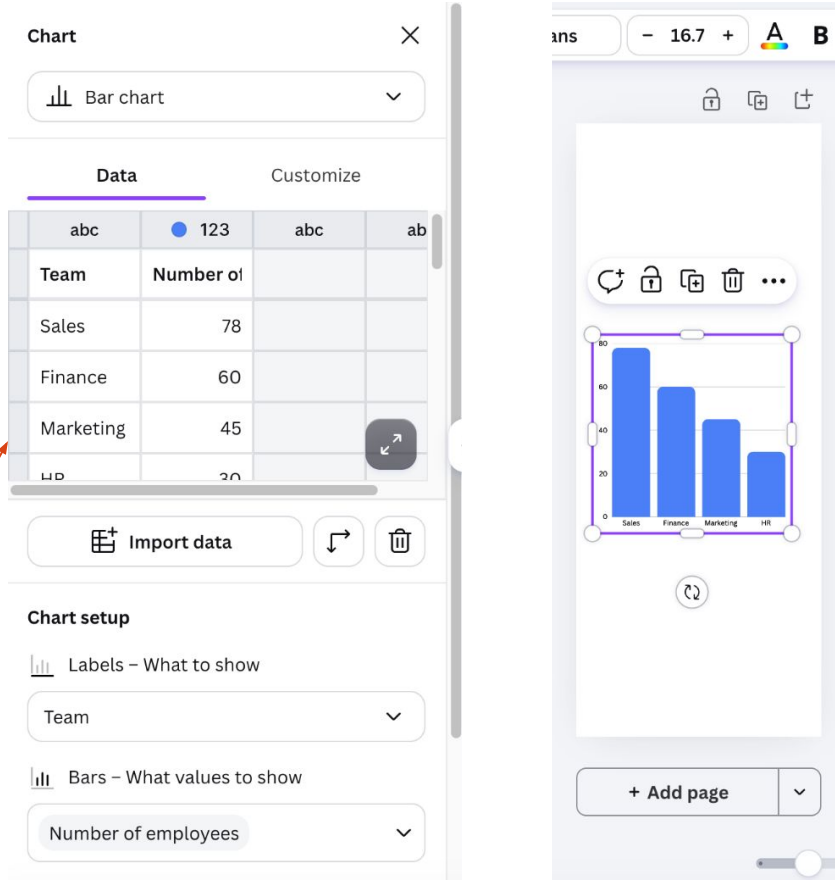
Creating Graphs 1/3



- In the “elements” section, select “charts.”
- You will be presented with many different chart and graph options, including bar charts, line graphs, pie charts, area charts, scatter plots, etc.

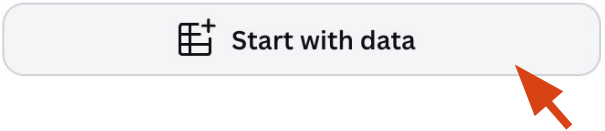
Creating Graphs 2/3

- If you already know which style graph you want to use, you can click directly on your selection, and a base graph will populate on your Canva page/project.
- From there, you can edit the data in the auto-populated table that Canva creates for you, which will automatically adjust the visual graph based on the data you input.

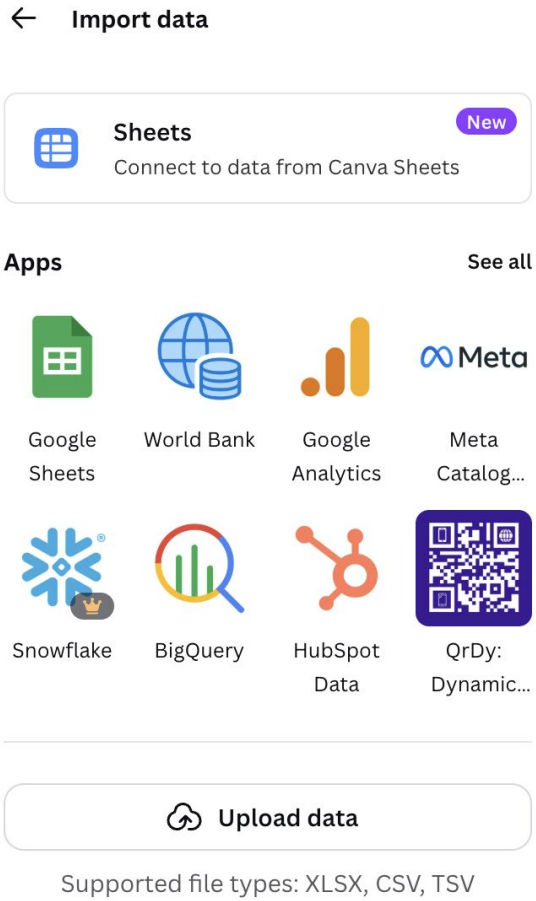


Creating Graphs 3/3

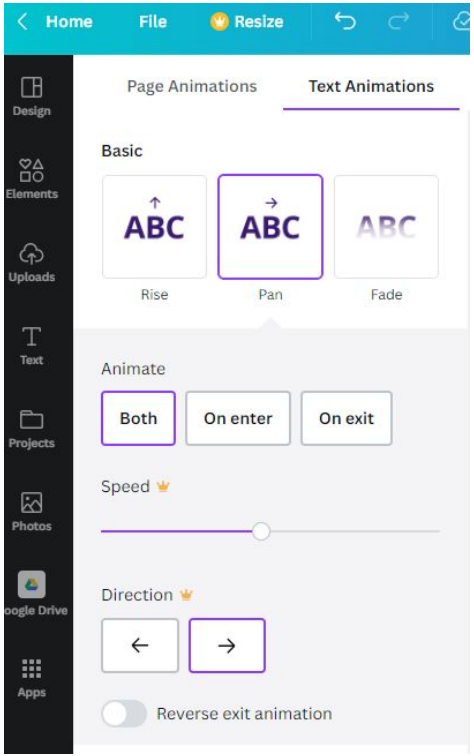
- You can also create charts or graphs in Canva by inputting your own data directly



- Canva allows you to link data through a variety of other files and/or platforms, so you don't have to reproduce your data by hand



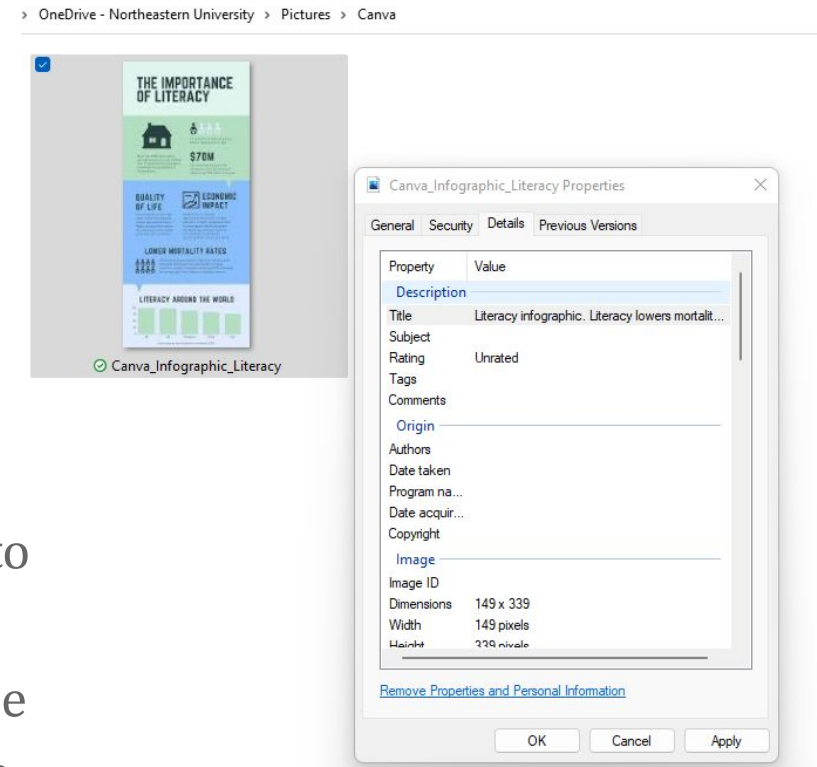
Adding Animation Effects



- There are multiple types of animations in Canva.
- To use animations, click on and select the feature you want to animate.
- Click on 'Animate' in the top menu, and review the types of Text Animations on the left-hand side of the screen. Hover your cursor over each type to preview how it looks.
- Page Animations apply the effect to all of the features on the slide.

Alt-Text

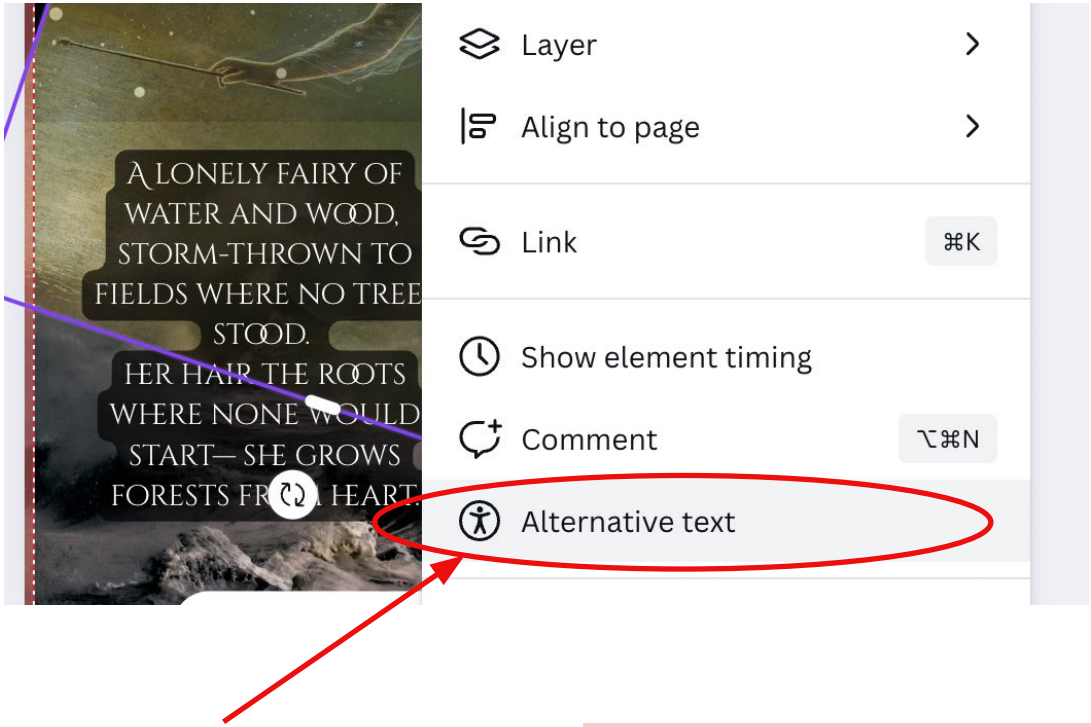
- Alt-text is a description of an image that conveys the image content and meaning. This descriptive text is attached to the image's file properties.
- People with low or no vision can use assistive technology like screen readers to hear the alt-text description of digital images. When a screen reader reaches the image, it will read the alt-text description out loud.



Based on : [Microsoft's How to write effective alt-text]

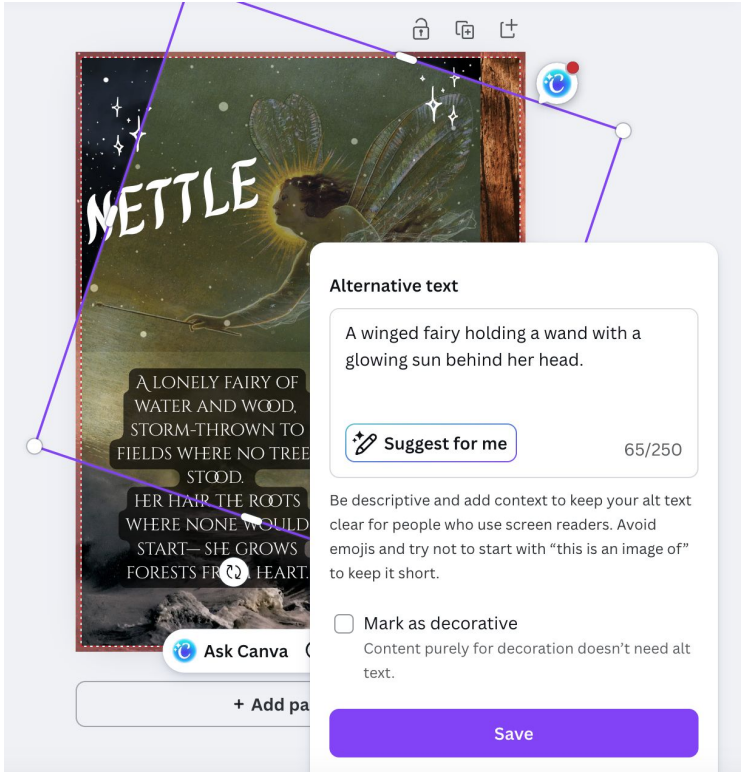
Adding Alt-Text in Canva 1/2

- In the Canva editing page, double-click on your image, and a menu will open to the right (the same menu as when you add layers).
- Click on the option for “Alternative text”.



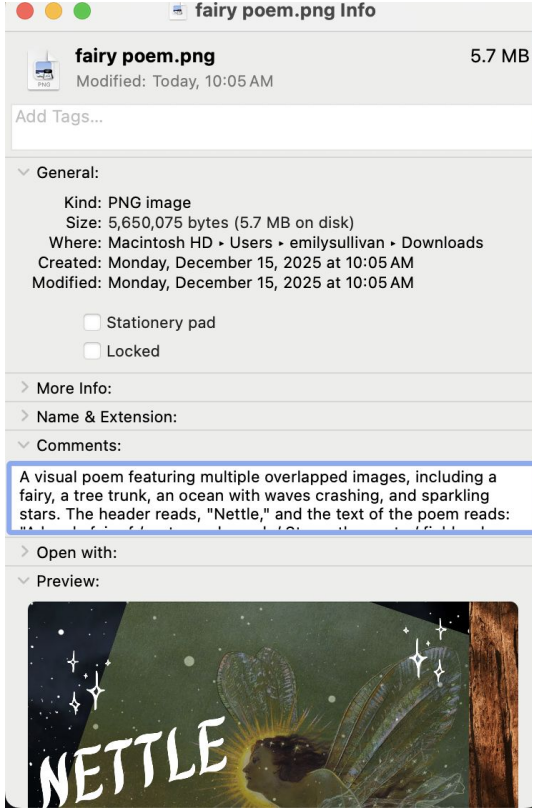
Adding Alt-Text in Canva 2/2

- A text bubble will appear where you can add the descriptive alt-text.
  - Note: this method means that you can add alt-text to each image separately, which is especially important if you are creating a file that contains multiple overlapping images or elements.



Adding Alt-Text to a downloaded image file

- You can export your infographic as an image and then add alt-text.
- Find the image in your file directory.
  - On PC: Right-click the image and select ‘Properties.’ Choose the ‘Details’ tab and click on the ‘Title’ field.
  - On Mac: Control-click the image and select ‘Get Info’ on Macs, then edit the ‘Comments’ field.
- Write a description of and insights from your infographic.



Feel free to ask questions at any point during the presentation!

Canva & AI Tools

Feel free to ask questions at any point during the presentation!

Using AI on Canva

- Canva has a number of built-in AI tools and features. If you choose to use these features, you should first consider:
  - Relevant AI policies and guidelines
  - The technical, conceptual, and ethical implications of using AI
  - Any use of AI must be appropriately cited (see our handout on Copyright and Fair Use for some guidance on citing AI). You can also explore the DITI's page on AI for more of our resources on this topic.
- Also note that, as with many of Canva's tools, some are paid and some are free. For the purposes of this module, we will only cover the features that are usable with the free membership.

AI Considerations 1/2



Technical

- There is a limited number of times you can use the free AI tools on Canva per month
- AI technology is experimental and can be unreliable (see Canva's disclaimer in the image above)★

Conceptual + Ethical

- Generative AI technology does cannot "create" independently; it draws from (often biased) training data comprising real peoples' work
- If you are creating an infographic using data, consider whether this is data that can ethically be shared with the AI tool (see our handouts on Data Privacy, Data Ethics, and AI Ethics for more on this topic)

AI Considerations 2/2

Before using AI features, ask yourself:

- Am I leveraging AI as a tool to accomplish my own creative and/or intellectual goals?
- Am I using AI to accomplish part of a task that I am still directing or am I using AI to do the entire task (e.g., prompting generative AI to make your infographic for you)?
- Am I using AI to accomplish something that I could do myself?
- How can I draft my prompt to be as precise as possible, tailoring expectations, instructions, and/or from what sources I want the AI tool to draw upon, with the least amount of prompting?

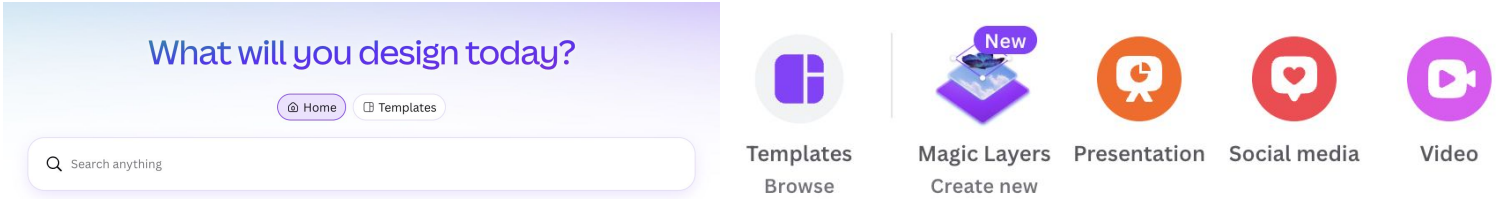
Feel free to ask questions at any point during the presentation!

Canva AI Tools

- For information on available AI tools by plan, see Understanding your AI usage by Canva
- Free accounts can use AI tools a limited number of times
- Tools include
  - Magic Layers
  - Magic Write
  - Canva AI
    - Generate text, images, or formulas
    - Design related prompts to Canva AI may require a paid account
  - Animation and voice tools

Magic Layers 1/2

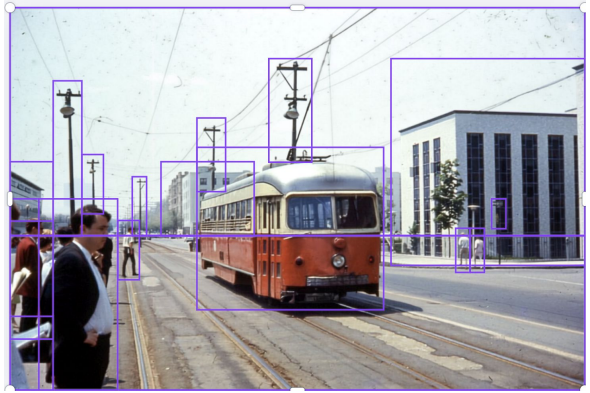
- "Magic Layers" uses AI technology to digitally separate visual elements of an image, allowing you to extract specific visuals, move visuals around within a single photo, etc.
- To use Canva's "Magic Layers" feature, **you have to start from the home page** (as opposed to editing your image directly in your project once you've already started). By pressing "Magic Layers," Canva will prompt you to upload your image.



Magic Layers 2/2

For example, here is a photo of the MBTA by David Wilson from Wikimedia Commons (CC BY 2.0). Using the Magic Layers feature, the image of the train can be separated from the background, which you could then copy and paste onto your own project.



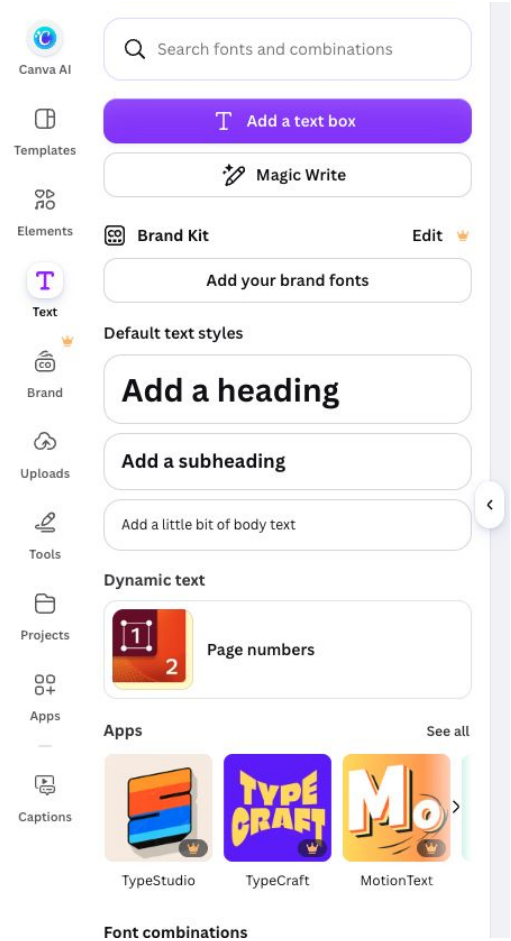




Magic Write

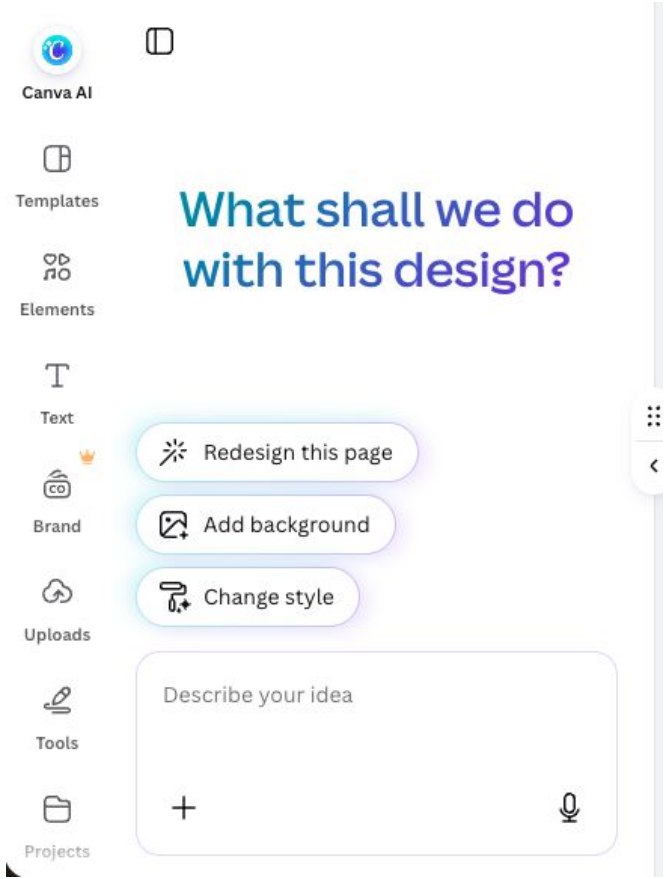
- Magic Write generates text based on a prompt
- To use Magic Write go to the Text menu, click Magic Write, then enter your prompt in the pop-up text box
- To upload files, click the plus icon in the lower left





Canva AI

- You can prompt Canva AI to generate text, images, or formula.
- Click the plus icon in the lower left to attach items to your prompt



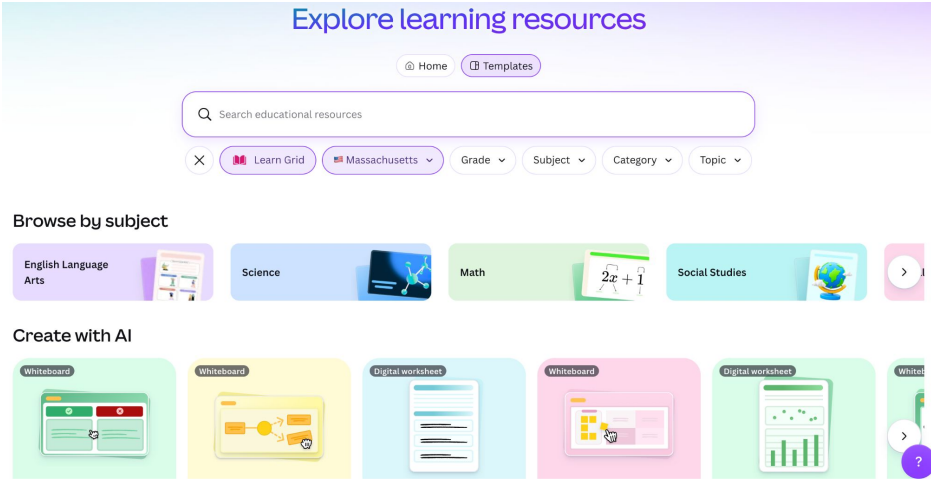
Other Canva AI Tools



Education a sub-page of Canva dedicated to teaching and learning resources, where you can use generative AI and textual prompts for new projects, or explore Canva's resources and templates



Canva Code is a generative AI technology that allows you to create code based on textual prompts



More Tips & Info to Consider

Feel free to ask questions at any point during the presentation!

Build a coherent argument or narrative

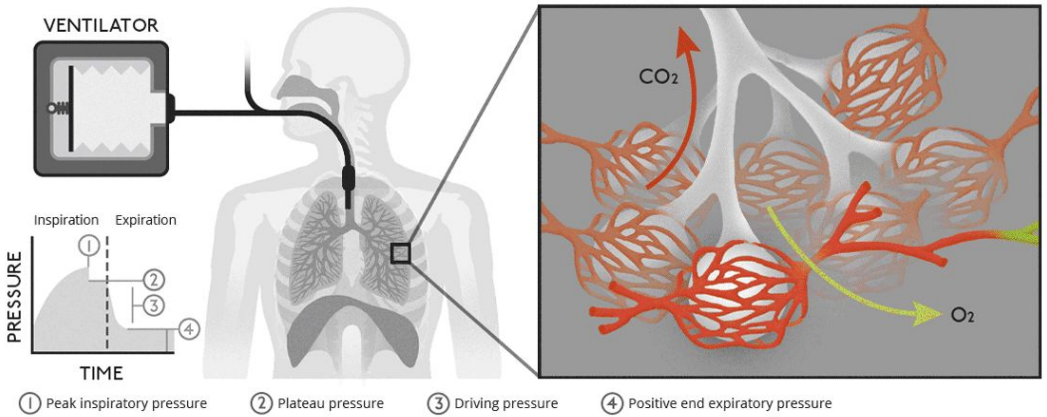
- Treat your infographic like any other form of argument, explanation, or narrative – be **intentional**, and **organize** your points chronologically or as ordered steps in a process.
- Put **main ideas front-and-center**, and consider having your points progress down orders of importance.
- Use **signposts** or **sections** to orient your audience, i.e. pairing each point with numbers, shifting color gradients, etc.

Some more tips

- Draw up an outline or storyboard **before** you build the graphic.
- Have a specific and **clear title**.
- Use **carefully-proofed syntax and vocabulary**, and explain terms/jargon.
- Have **proper citations**.
- Don’t mix too many visual types within your infographic. Keep a consistent font, color scheme, animation effects, design, formatting, etc.
- Limit text – keep negative space for the graphical component.

Infographic Formats 1/2

- **Static** infographics:
  - Typically fixed information a still image.
- **Motion** infographics:
  - Typically fixed information. Display output is animated, or moving.

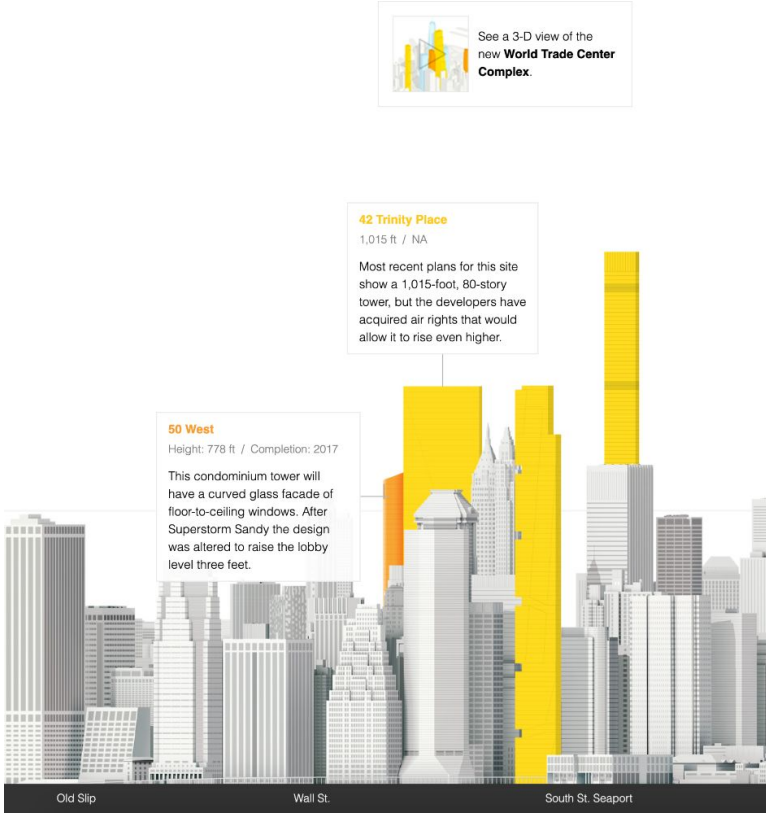


"Biology of ventilation," tapletopwhale.com

Feel free to ask questions at any point during the presentation!

Infographic Formats 2/2

- **Interactive** infographics:
  - Can be fixed or dynamic information input.
  - User interaction consists of searching for specific data, actively shaping the content displayed, and choosing which information is accessed and visualized.



Source: *"The New New York Skyline," National Geographic*

Feel free to ask questions at any point during the presentation!

For Further Consideration: Accurately Representing Data in Visuals and Infographics

—Developed in collaboration with BARI

Feel free to ask questions at any point during the presentation!

Data Presentation Tips

- **Create your own tables**, or make sure to use only images that are shared with permissions that support reuse—and always cite your sources!
- **Be sure to present your data *accurately*—**be mindful that your charts, graphs, maps, and infographics are scaled and structured to present data and conclusions *completely* and *correctly*.
- **Use visual representations of numbers—**this will help concretize abstract concepts.
- **Label judiciously**, but don't overwhelm the viewer with dense text.
- **Beware of trying to make too many points in one graphic—**focus on the big takeaways.

Limitations of Some Data Presentation Methods: Charts, Graphs, Diagrams, Maps

- The **structure** and **scale** of charts and graphs could be **manipulated** to amplify or diminish differences.
- **Different types** of graphs and charts work better for some types of data than others—for example, a pie chart and a line graph might not both be able to represent the same data accurately.
- A chart with **too much information** will be difficult to understand, but **too little information** could be an indication that data has been cherry-picked to support an argument.
- There is **limited space** in an infographic for in-depth analysis; nuances can be flattened and obfuscated.

Misrepresentation of Data

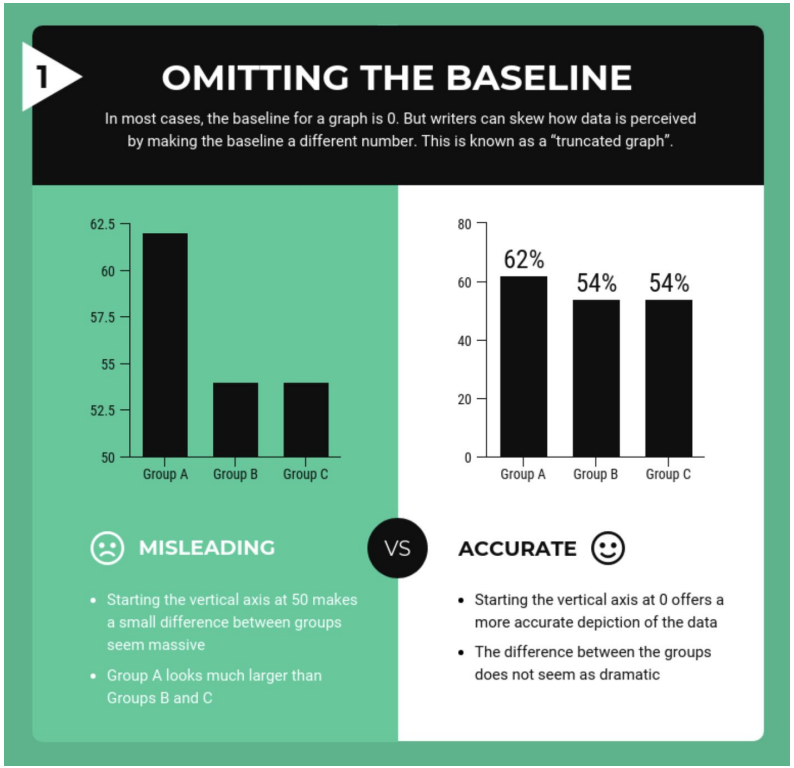
- From D.B. Resnik, in the *International Encyclopedia of the Social & Behavioral Sciences*, 2001: "...what does it mean to *misrepresent* data? As a minimal answer to this question, one can define 'misrepresentation of data' as '**communicating honestly reported data in a deceptive manner.**'"
- This online book from The Data School covers some common ways data could be misrepresented at multiple points in the process of gathering, analyzing, and presenting findings on data-based research.

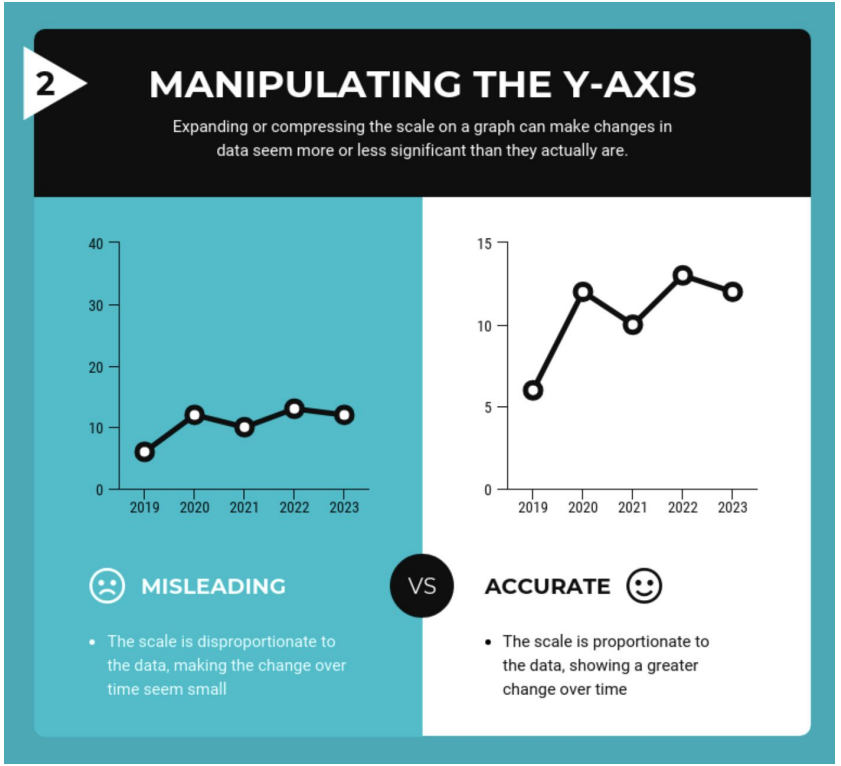
Limitations of Charts, Diagrams, Graphs, & Maps

Consider these questions as you review the examples in this section:

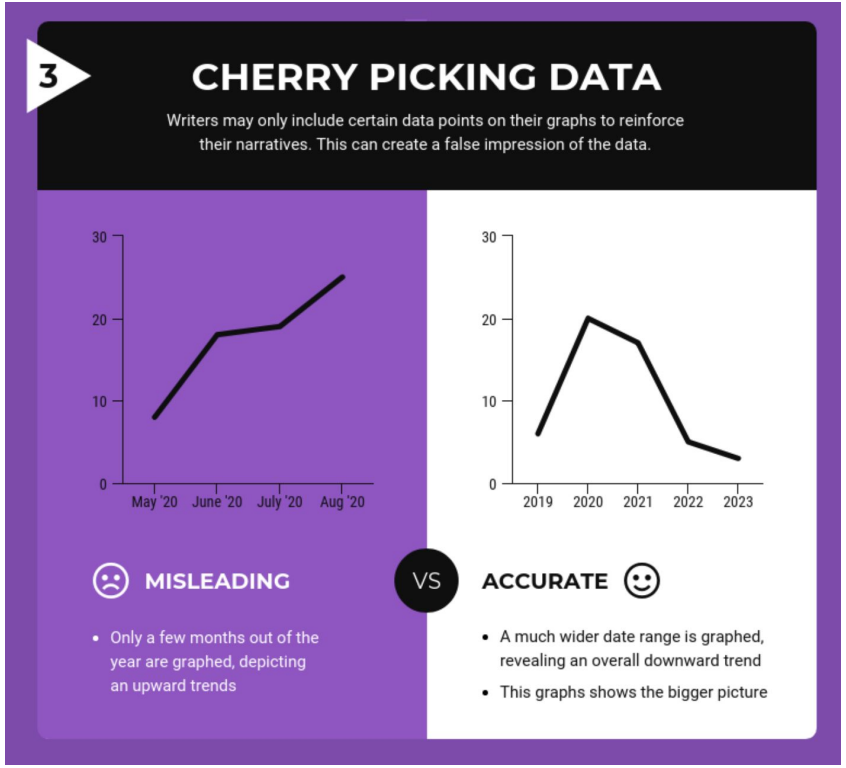
- What **commonalities** do you notice among the more misleading and more accurate versions of graphs and charts in these examples?
- How would you define "**accuracy**" in the context of data presentation? Why is that question essential to ask?
- In what **contexts** does it make the most sense to use these kinds of visuals to present data? Are there other times where they're inappropriate? How so?

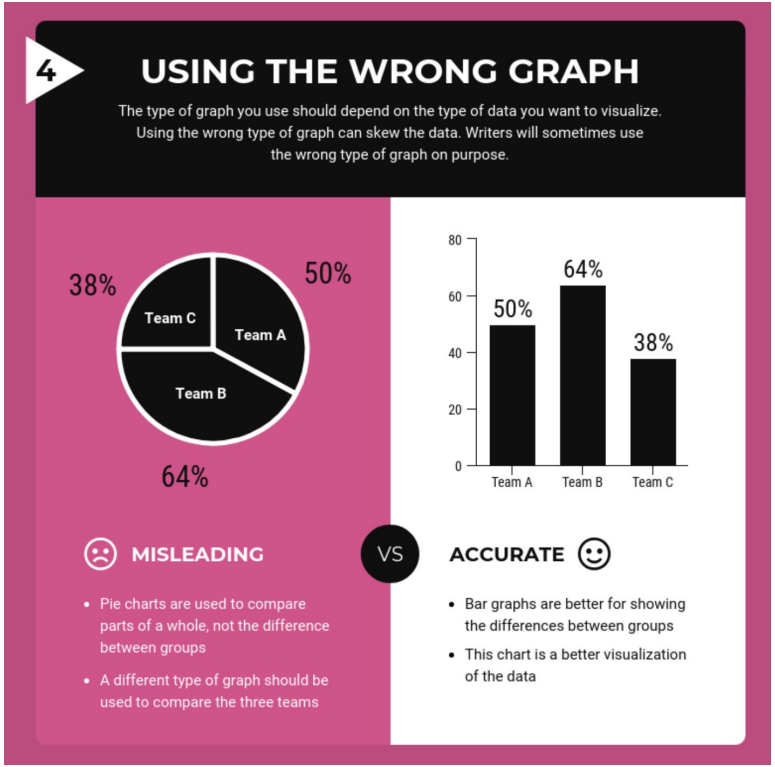
Misleading axis representation



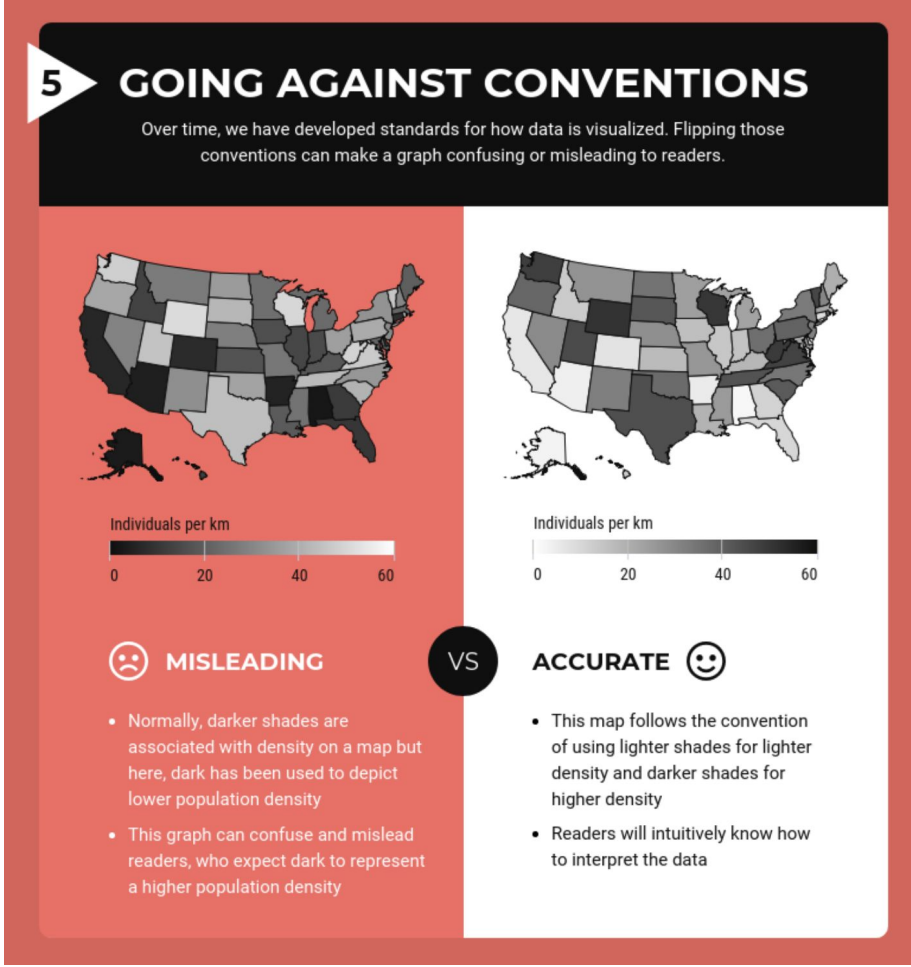


Misleading data and graph selection





Misleading map representations



Your turn!

1. Go to https://www.canva.com/ and log in or sign up
2. Select a size
3. Select a template
4. Try adding a chart or importing an image
5. Discuss
    a. What is the main argument of your infographic?
    b. Are there other elements you would want to add to communicate your argument?
    c. Are there any data misrepresentation risks you might run into?

For Further Exploration

DITI infographics handout

DITI accessibility handout

DITI data privacy handout

NULab Meet the Method: Canva

See also the Beginner's Guide, published by Canva

Thank you!

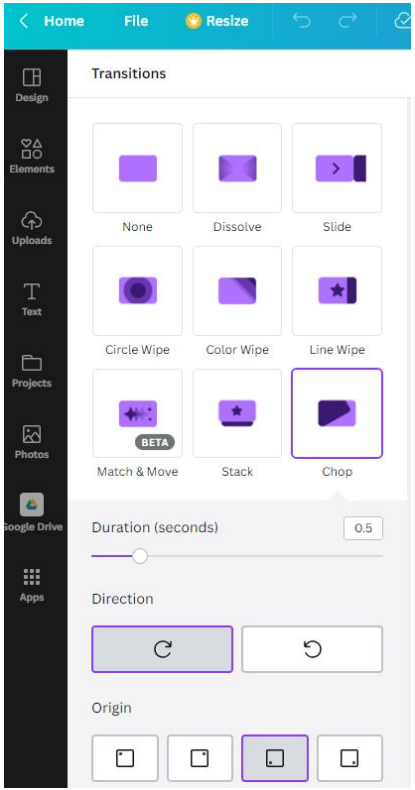
Developed by DITI Research and Teaching Fellows: Emily Sullivan, Zhen Guo, Claire Lavarreda, Carlos Arriaga Serrano, Kasya O'Connor Grant, Dipa Desai, Javier Rosario, Mel Williams, Tiffany Cruz, Sara Morrell, and Yuntong Ji

- For more information on DITI, please see: https://bit.ly/diti-about
- Schedule an appointment with us! https://bit.ly/diti-meeting
- If you have any questions, contact us at: nulab.info@gmail.com
- We'd love your feedback! Please fill out a short survey here: https://bit.ly/diti-feedback

Canva For Further Exploration: Transitions and Audio/Video

Feel free to ask questions at any point during the presentation!

Adding Slide Transitions



- Slide transitions animate the movement from one slide to the next.
- To use transitions in Canva, click on the three dots that pop up above the slide in the preview deck at the bottom of the screen.
- Click 'Add transition' and review the options on the left side of the screen. Hover your cursor over each option to preview the transition effect.
- Once you choose a slide transition, Canva will let you adjust the duration and direction of the transition.

Use Audio/Video for Impact

- You can upload audio from your computer or record your own audio within Canva under the Uploads tab. Canva also has free audio and video you can use under the Elements tab.
- You can upload a video saved to your computer or link to an online video using the Canva Apps tab, which connects to YouTube and other platforms.
- Once you add in the audio or video to the Canva presentation, you can click on it to customize audio and video effects.

